

Palm Tungsten T3

The top-of-the-line handheld in the Tungsten T series—the Tungsten T3—features the same sliding design found in its predecessors. It betters the older models with a display that stretches automatically to 320 x 480 pixels when you open the slider. Couple that with a faster processor and more memory, and the T3 certainly becomes a package for power users.

Encased in a brushed aluminium body, the T3 weighs 155 gm and measures 4.3 x 3 x 0.66 inches when closed—slightly longer than the T and T2. The sides are slightly tapered to better fit your hand. The front panel buttons have been re-designed, and it has an oblong five-way navigator, around which four oddly-shaped application buttons are arranged.

The design and placement of the rest of the controls are the same as those of its predecessors. A new addition is a hinged door for the card slot when no card is inserted, so the plastic dummy cards that ship with the other models are no longer needed. Deviating from the plastic snap-on screen covers of the T and T2, the T3 screen is covered by a removable leather flip. The build quality is great, and you can expect years of faithful service.

The T3 is powered by an ultra-fast Intel XScale 400 MHz (PXA 255) CPU, and has 64 MB of in-built memory, 52 MB of which is available. Other features included are voice recording, Bluetooth and media playback. But the best is yet to come: Though it runs the same OS as the T2-v5.2.1, the T3's stretch display and virtual graffiti area adds a dimension to the user experience.

Close the slider, and you'll see the 320 x 320 screen with a taskbar at the bottom. Open it and the display stretches automatically to 320 x 480—the taskbar still at the bottom. The applications shrink and expand when you close or open the slider.

Tapping the 'expand' button displays the virtual graffiti area and the application icons. The main advantage of the virtual graffiti area is that you can remap any of the four silkscreen buttons to any application of your choice, and the icon changes accordingly. Also, the Preferences module lets you change the view to a virtual keyboard, or a wide mode that hides the buttons at the side and provides dedicated writing areas. Tap the rotate button on the task bar to rotate the screen 180 degrees to landscape mode. The taskbar moves, and the five-way navigator, too, changes its orientation automatically. You can set rotation for either left- or right-handed use in Preferences.

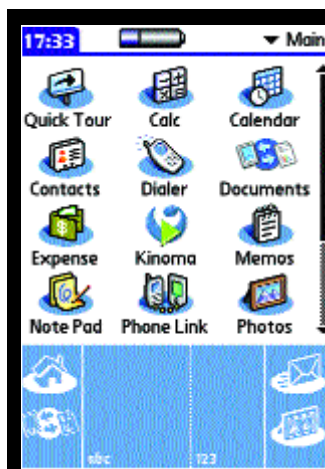
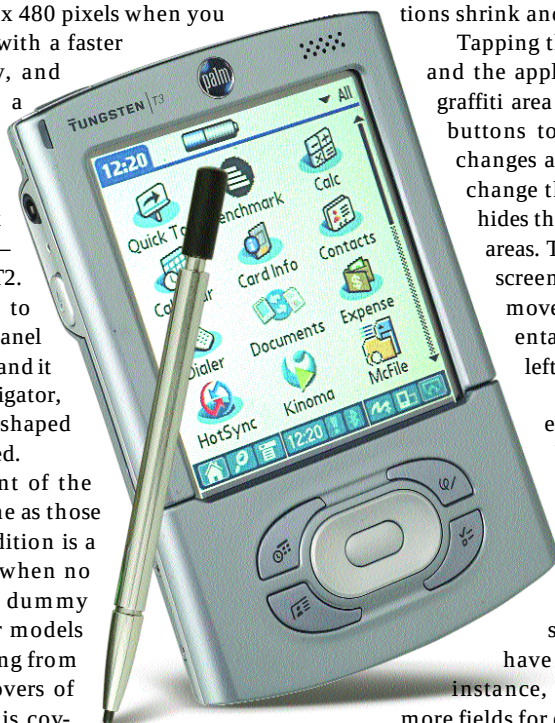
Apart from standard applications such as Calendar, Contacts, Tasks and Voice Memo, you get a bunch of useful applications such as Documents to Go, VersaMail, Dialer, SMS, Palm Photos, RealOne Mobile Player and Kinoma Player, Adobe Reader, Palm Reader, BlueBoard, BlueChat, Java and Palm Web Pro browser are included on the CD. This may seem like a standard line-up, but quite a few enhancements have been made to the applications in the T3. For instance, Contacts now support multiple addresses, and more fields for e-mail addresses, instant messenger accounts and Web sites for each entry.

The 4 KB limit for memos has now been increased to 32 KB. An Agenda view in the calendar displays appointments, tasks due and e-mail. Documents To Go v6—the latest—supports native MS-Word and Excel formats, so no conversion is necessary.

Bluetooth features also have some enhancements: you can pick a Bluetooth device from an existing list, or from your trusted devices, instead of searching for a device to pair with.

In terms of usage and performance, the T3 is great to run heavy applications such as 3D games and movie clips. The fast processor makes short work of whatever you throw at it. Viewing applications in landscape mode is a treat—especially reading eBooks, working on spreadsheets and viewing photos. The power switch on the top lacks depth, and you need to press it a little hard. Apart from that, the ergonomics are excellent. The 900 mAh battery gave us an hour and 55 minutes of continuous playback in Kinoma.

Overall, the T3 is a PDA power user's dream, and is a scorcher both in terms of raw power and features. The high price tag may deter quite a few prospective buyers, though.



Top: The T3's stretch display with virtual graffiti
Right: Wider possibilities with landscape mode



+ Stretch display and landscape mode view
- Low battery life
Price: Rs 26,499

Palm Tungsten T3		C+
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	